While the first "confirmed" Zodiac murders began in **December 1968**, several earlier unsolved crimes in California share striking similarities to his known M.O. or have been directly linked by investigators and the killer himself.

Potential "Pre-Zodiac" Murders (1962–1967)

These cases are frequently cited by amateur sleuths and law enforcement as potential early crimes of the Zodiac:

- **Ray Davis (Oceanside, 1962):** A taxi driver was shot in the back of the head. Notably, the killer called the police beforehand to announce his intention to murder a driver, a taunting behavior similar to later Zodiac communications.
- **Robert Domingos & Linda Edwards (Santa Barbara, 1963):** A teenage couple was shot with a .22 caliber weapon while sunbathing at a beach. The killer used Winchester Western Super X ammunition, the same type found at the Zodiac's first confirmed crime scene in 1968.
- **Johnny & Joyce Swindle (San Diego, 1964):** Newlyweds were gunned down while walking on Ocean Beach. Like the 1968 murders, the attacker used a .22 caliber firearm.
- **Cheri Jo Bates (Riverside, 1966):** An 18-year-old student was stabbed to death outside her college library. In a 1971 letter, the Zodiac claimed credit for this murder, stating there were "a lot more down there". However, the Riverside Police Department remains adamant that she was not a Zodiac victim.

Comparison of Known vs. Suspected Cases

Victim(s)	Date	Location	Weapon	Status
Ray Davis	April 1962	Oceanside, CA	.22 caliber	Suspected
Domingos & Edwards	June 1963	Gaviota, CA	.22 caliber	Suspected
Swindle Couple	Feb 1964	San Diego, CA	.22 caliber	Suspected
Cheri Jo Bates	Oct 1966	Riverside, CA	Knife	Suspected
Faraday & Jensen	Dec 1968	Benicia, CA	.22 caliber	**Confirmed**

While the Zodiac claimed 37 victims in his letters, only five deaths remain officially confirmed by investigators.

Are you looking for details on a **specific suspect** linked to these early cases, such as Arthur Leigh Allen or Gary Poste?

13 sites

- Zodiac Killer - Wikipedia
  For the 1971 film about the serial killer, see The Zodiac Killer (film). * The Zodiac is the pseudonym of an unidentified serial k...

  Wikipedia

- The Zodiac Killer: A Timeline | HISTORY
  Nov 8, 2017 — Robert Domingos and his fiancé Linda Edwards were seniors at Lompoc High School in Santa Barbara County in Southern California. On...

  History.com

- Group claims it has solved the identity of the Zodiac Killer as law ...
  While the Riverside Police Department could not comment on the man identified by the Case Breakers, RPD public information officer...

  CNN

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confirmed Zodiac murders - list

While the Zodiac Killer claimed responsibility for 37 murders in his taunting letters, law enforcement and the FBI officially confirm only **five deaths** across four separate attacks in Northern California.

The confirmed fatal victims are David Arthur Faraday and Betty Lou Jensen, killed on December 20, 1968, in Benicia [1]; Darlene Elizabeth Ferrin, shot on July 4, 1969, in Vallejo [2, 3]; Cecelia Ann Shepard, stabbed on September 27, 1969, in Napa County and died two days later [4, 5]; and Paul Lee Stine, shot on October 11, 1969, in San Francisco [6].

There were also confirmed survivors. Michael Renault Mageau was shot alongside Darlene Ferrin and survived [1]. Bryan Calvin Hartnell was stabbed with Cecelia Shepard and survived, providing a description of the killer [4, 7].

The official timeline of confirmed attacks is as follows:

Date	Location	Victims	Outcome
Dec 20, 1968	Benicia, CA	Faraday & Jensen	Both Deceased
July 4, 1969	Vallejo, CA	Ferrin & Mageau	1 Deceased, 1 Survived
Sept 27, 1969	Napa County, CA	Shepard & Hartnell	1 Deceased, 1 Survived
Oct 11, 1969	San Francisco, CA	Paul Stine	Deceased

Would you like to explore the Zodiac's famous ciphers or see which **suspects** are most closely linked to these specific crime scenes?

9 sites

- Zodiac Killer suspects - Wikipedia

  Background. The Zodiac Killer claimed in messages to newspapers to have committed thirty-seven murders. Investigators agree on sev...

Wikipedia

- The Zodiac Killer: What to Know About the Serial Murderer's ...

  Dec 21, 2025 — NEED TO KNOW * The Zodiac Killer murdered at least five people in the late 1960s and claimed to be responsible for dozens more dea...

People.com

- Zodiac Killer - Wikipedia

  Contents * 1 Murders and correspondence. 1.1 Lake Herman Road murders. 1.2 Blue Rock Springs murder. 1.2.1 Ferrin–Zodiac prior rel...

Wikipedia

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re-do the list with full naames and weapon

Here is the updated list of the

Zodiac's five confirmed fatal victims, including their full names and the weapons used in each attack:

1. **David Arthur Faraday** & **Betty Lou Jensen**

1. **Date:** December 20, 1968

2. **Weapon:** .22-caliber semi-automatic pistol (specifically Winchester Western Super X copper-coated bullets)

2. **Darlene Elizabeth Ferrin**

0. **Date:** July 4, 1969

1. **Weapon:** 9mm semi-automatic pistol (Luger or Browning Hi-Power)

2. *Note: Her companion, Michael Renault Mageau, survived this shooting.*

3. **Cecelia Ann Shepard**

0. **Date:** September 27, 1969

1. **Weapon:** Knife (described as a long-bladed hunting knife approximately 10–12 inches long)

2. *Note: Her companion, Bryan Calvin Hartnell, survived the stabbing.*

4. **Paul Lee Stine**

0. **Date:** October 11, 1969

1. **Weapon:** 9mm semi-automatic pistol (likely the same 9mm used in the July 4 attack)

Would you like to see a breakdown of the **physical evidence** left at these scenes, such as the bloody shirt piece or fingerprints?

While there is no definitive forensic proof, recent investigations and longstanding theories have proposed a connection between the Zodiac Killer and the 1947 murder of Elizabeth Short, known as the Black Dahlia.

New Evidence: The Marvin Margolis Theory

As of late 2025 and early 2026, a new investigation by code-breaker Alex Baber and supported by Michael Connelly's podcast "Killer in the Code" has brought significant attention to **Marvin Margolis** (also known as Marvin Merrill) as a suspect for both crimes.

- **Cipher Solutions:** Baber claims to have cracked the Zodiac's "Z13" cipher using AI and traditional cryptography, revealing the name "Marvin Merrill".
- **The "Elizabeth" Sketch:** A 1992 drawing by Margolis titled "Elizabeth" reportedly shows a mutilated woman with the word "ZODIAC" hidden in the shading.
- **Expert Backing:** Former NSA cryptographers and retired LAPD detectives have reviewed and endorsed these findings.
- **Margolis's Background:** He was a WWII Navy corpsman with medical training, lived with Elizabeth Short shortly before her death, and was an early suspect in the Black Dahlia case.

The George Hodel Theory

Another prominent theory, championed by retired LAPD detective Steve Hodel, points to his father, **Dr. George Hodel**.

- **Signature Overlap:** Hodel identifies 32 "crime signatures" shared between the two cases, including taunting letters and specific posing of victims.
- **Surgical Skill:** Like Margolis, George Hodel had the advanced surgical skills required to bisect Elizabeth Short's body.
- **DA Files:** Secret tapes from 1950 recorded George Hodel saying, "Supposin' I did kill the Black Dahlia. They couldn't prove it now".

Reasons for Skepticism

Despite these theories, many historians and investigators remain unconvinced due to several factors:

- **Different MOs:** The Black Dahlia murder involved extreme torture and dismemberment, whereas the confirmed Zodiac murders were typically quick shootings or stabbings.
- **Timeline and Geography:** The crimes are separated by over 20 years and roughly 400 miles.
- **Lack of Physical Evidence:** There is currently no matching DNA, fingerprints, or ballistics connecting any single suspect to both cases.

Would you like to dive deeper into the **Z13 cipher solution** or see the composite sketches comparing these suspects to the famous Zodiac drawing?